Every night on television screens across the country, you have a live courtroom drama with news anchors sometimes playing judge, jury and prosecutor, and ‘guilty till proven innocent’ being the presiding mantra. Familiar talking heads pop out of every debate, often swiftly moving from one channel to another. Studio ‘talk’ is cheap; solid ground reporting needs deep pockets. Journalistic laziness and a warped business model have ensured that loud and highly opinionated court martials have become a staple diet on news channels. It is often rather inane, high on noise and low on substance, but it is a rough democracy of opinion. The debate is robust, if not always constructive, and can nevertheless be entertaining.

Election time is no different. Every political party has to line up party spokespersons to defend their position. Here again, the battle was unequal. The BJP had a strong line-up of articulate, TV-savvy leaders; the Congress’s best did not want to go out and face the bouncers being thrown at them by aggressive anchors.

In June 2013, Ajay Maken was put in charge of the Congress’s communication department. Maken had proved to be an enthusiastic sports minister, and the party was hoping he would bring some of that energy to this key post ahead of the elections. His predecessor, Janardhan Dwivedi, was an old-world neta who preferred poetry to sound bites. I got the feeling that he was part of that frustrated group within the Congress who actually derived vicarious pleasure from seeing the government embarrassed. Congress gossip was that Dwivedi had been given the job because he had taught Hindi to Sonia Gandhi!

Maken’s first task was to try and ensure that the Congress got its most eloquent voices to speak up for the party. His team prepared an exhaustive list of leaders to appear on television. But as a Maken aide put it, ‘It was a thankless task. None of our major leaders who were now ministers wanted to come on TV debates.’ I asked one of the ministers what the reason was. He said, ‘Why should we come on a cockfight on television and make a fool of ourselves!’

Some Congress ministers like Anand Sharma made it clear to Maken that they would only appear in occasional one-on-one interviews. ‘You don’t